things straight.

I never thought seriously about anything other than signing a new contract with the club I loved. It was just a question of getting the details right: a new deal was going to mean a major commitment on both sides. I needed to know that United respected my value to them and I don't think united directors Peter Kenyon and David Gill, who handled things at the club's end, had a problem with that. They certainly did everything they could to make things go smoothly and made sure they honored every single promise. I'm very grateful to them for that. I'm grateful that I had the right man—the best man—sitting on my side of the table as well.

Tony Stephens has been my agent since 1995. He'd been a director at Wembley in the past and was working as a consultant on the project to build Huddersfield's new ground, the McAlpine Stadium, when I first got to know him. I remember one time in particular: Tony invited a group of the young United lads—me, Gary, Phil and Ben Thornley—to a Bryan Adams concert. We ended up wangling our way onto the stage for what was a pretty amazing night. That same evening, Tony actually had another quite important bit of business going on in the area at the same time: arranging a transfer for Alan Shearer, a player he was already looking after, from Blackburn Rovers to Newcastle United.

I'm not sure when or where we were actually introduced. I do remember clearly, though, something Tony said during our very first conversation. It's stuck with me ever since and I don't think he's forgotten it either.

'Soccer's the most important thing, David. That's what you do. You must make sure nothing ever gets in the way of that.'

Later, when we talked about him representing me, Tony described his job as making sure I didn't have to worry about anything other than playing. He thought that was what an agent should be all about: taking the pressure off his clients so that they could get on with their jobs. That's exactly what he's done for me ever since. Tony's someone I know I can put absolute trust in, whatever the circumstances. Sometimes it'll feel like he's fussing around, organizing every little detail of my life. He has the kind of character that means he'll walk into a room full of complete strangers and have them all working on a plan and a schedule together within about fifteen minutes. Everybody else may be losing their heads. He'll be the one in control. And that's what I've needed over the last eight years and still do: now more than ever.